

What Shakespeare Observes About Being Human

A synthesis from the text alone. No outside criticism was used. Every claim here should trace to lines in corpus/works/; the per-play notes in notes/ carry the act and scene citations. Where this essay says “the play shows,” it means the action, not a character’s opinion.

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How to read this

Shakespeare almost never tells you what life is. He has a character tell you, and then he puts an event beside the speech that the speech cannot absorb. That is the single most consistent habit in the whole corpus, and it is the key to everything below.

Jaques says a life ends “sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything” (*As You Like It* II.7), and in the next moment Orlando carries in old Adam, alive, hungry, and about to be fed. Ulysses explains that when “degree” is lost, “appetite, an universal wolf” must “last eat up himself” (*Troilus* I.3), and then restores order by rigging a lottery that fails. Portia says mercy “droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven” (*Merchant* IV.1), and it moves nobody; what saves Antonio is a sharper reading of the same law. Sonnet 116 says love “alters not,” and Sonnet 117, next to it, confesses that the speaker “hoisted sail to all the winds.” Macbeth lays out, before the murder, a complete argument against it, that “bloody instructions, which being taught, return / To plague th’ inventor” (I.7), and then commits it. Cassius says “the fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves” (*Julius Caesar* I.2) and dies by his own hand on a misreading of a battlefield.

So the first thing the corpus observes about human beings is this: **we are the animal that can state the truth about its condition and cannot act on it.** The gap between the maxim and the life is not a flaw in particular people. It is where people live. Every observation that follows should be read with that in mind. None of them is offered as a rule for living, because the plays spend five acts each showing that rules for living are what people say on the way to doing something else.

What follows is organized in three parts: what we are made of, what we do to each other, and what happens to us. A fourth part says what, after all of that, the corpus actually teaches, and what it refuses to teach.

Part One: What we are made of

1. Underneath everything we are a bare animal who needs more than survival

Lear, in the storm, looks at a naked beggar and says: “Thou art the thing itself: unaccommodated man is no more but such a poor, bare, forked animal as thou art” (III.4). Hamlet calls the same creature “the paragon of animals” and, in the same breath, “this quintessence of dust” (II.2). Isabella says man is “most ignorant of what he’s most assured, / His glassy essence” (Measure II.2). The plays keep stripping people: Lear of his hundred knights, Richard II of his crown, Timon of his gold, Gloucester of his eyes, Antonio of his occupation. What is left when the stripping is done is the same in every case, and the plays do not pretend it is noble.

But the corpus does not stop there, and the second half matters more. When Regan asks why Lear needs any followers at all, he answers: “O, reason not the need: our basest beggars / Are in the poorest thing superfluous: / Allow not nature more than nature needs, / Man’s life is cheap as beast’s” (II.4). The thing that makes a human life different from an animal’s is exactly the part that is not necessary. We need more than we need. The storm scene confirms it: stripped to “the thing itself,” Lear goes mad. The bare forked animal is not a man; a man is the bare forked animal plus the things he cannot justify needing.

2. Knowing and doing are separate faculties, and the gap runs in both directions

This is the corpus’s central finding about the mind. Hamlet knows what to do and cannot do it; the play calls this “thinking too precisely on th’event” (IV.4) and then shows that his one unthinking act, the sword through the arras, kills the wrong man and starts every later death. Macbeth has the opposite trouble: he knows the deed is wrong, knows its cost, and cannot *not* do it once the thought is in him. Brutus reasons with real care in his orchard and arrives at murder. Richard II sees everything about kingship, that the crown is hollow, that he “needs friends,” that he has “wasted time” (V.5), and sees it only in prison, when seeing is useless. King John says “There is no sure foundation set on blood” (IV.2), and says it only after his lords have left. The histories make it a pattern: **insight arrives when it can no longer be used.**

The Rape of Lucrece gives the purest specimen. Tarquin lies awake and lists every reason not to do it, in better words than any moralist could: the deed is “a dream, a breath, a froth of fleeting joy,” it will ruin his name, Collatine is his friend, the prize once had is worthless. Then he goes, and the poem shows how: every obstacle, the locked doors, the wind at the candle, the needle in the glove,

is reread as a trial that proves the prize worth having, until desire is “captain” and reason is for old men. The poem is not interested in whether he is a monster. It is interested in how a man who can see talks himself blind.

The comedies say the same thing more lightly. In *All's Well*, the King argues that honour should come from deeds, not birth, and then forces a marriage by rank. Bertram hears the finest lines in the play about late remorse and goes straight on lying. *Troilus and Cressida* is the harshest case: Ulysses is right about degree, right about time, right about Cressida, and his cleverness produces nothing but a prouder Ajax. The note on that play puts it exactly: “almost every wise saying is true and almost no wise saying helps.”

The reader should take this seriously. The plays are not saying people are stupid. They are saying that understanding is one thing and the power to act on it is another, and that these are kept in separate hands with what looks like deliberate cruelty. Carlisle tells Richard II that “wise men ne’er sit and wail their woes, / But presently prevent the ways to wail” (III.2). He is right, and Richard cannot do it, and Carlisle himself is shortly under arrest.

3. Nobody learns by being told; feeling comes before seeing

Kent tells Lear in the first scene exactly what is true and is banished for it. The Fool tells him in rhymes for two acts. Lear learns only when the rain wets him. Gloucester learns only when he cannot see, and says, when asked how he sees the world now, “I see it feelingly” (IV.6). Timon’s steward says the money is gone, and Timon will not hear it; he learns in the woods, digging for roots. Leontes is not deceived by anyone; he builds the lie himself in real time, and every argument against it makes him more certain. Camillo says you cannot talk a person out of a belief that was never reasoned into, and he is right. What reaches Leontes is his son’s death, the one loss he cannot reinterpret.

Leonato in *Much Ado* states the principle for everyone: “everyone can master a grief but he that has it” (V.1). He says it minutes after wishing his daughter dead. The play lets the man who was cruel in his certainty be right in his pain. Romeo says the same, more brutally: “Hang up philosophy! / Unless philosophy can make a Juliet” (III.3). Comfort offered by someone who is not suffering is, in this corpus, an insult.

The implication is uncomfortable, and the plays mean it to be: your understanding of other people’s lives is limited by what you have been spared. The comfortable cannot feel, and so cannot see. Lear, mad, grasps this about himself: “O, I have ta’en / Too little care of this!” (III.4), and the “this” is the poor he governed for eighty years without noticing.

4. Belief outruns evidence, and the mind supplies what it wants to find

Othello demands “ocular proof” and is satisfied by a report of a beard being wiped on a handkerchief. He never sees anything. Leontes needs nothing at all. Claudio in *Much Ado* sees a woman at a window and supplies the name. Brutus reads a forged letter and finds his own thoughts in it. Caesar’s two parties both read the same lightning as a sign in their favour; Cicero’s one real line is that “men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves” (I.3). Macbeth’s witches tell only truths, and Banquo hears the same words and does nothing; the trap closes because Macbeth builds it. Hamlet says it flatly: “there is nothing either good or bad but thinking makes it so” (II.2).

The corpus’s precise contribution here is that **evidence is downstream of disposition**. The Friar and Beatrice read Hero’s blush with goodwill and are right; Claudio and the Prince read it with suspicion already planted and are wrong. Same blush. If you have decided someone is false, their face will prove it. If you have decided they are true, so will that. Cymbeline’s king says of his poisoning queen, “It had been vicious / To have mistrusted her” (V.5), and the play does not disagree with him, even though the trust nearly killed everyone. Iachimo, who trusts nothing and tests everything, ends on his knees. The plays prefer the posture of trust and show, without flinching, what it costs.

5. Desire moves faster than the self, and then calls itself reason

A Midsummer Night’s Dream puts flower juice on the eyelids and then lets the drugged man explain his new love as recovered health: “Now do I wish it, love it, long for it, / And will for evermore be true to it” (IV.1). The charm on Demetrius is never lifted. Proteus, in *Two Gentlemen*, describes his own inconstancy exactly while it is happening: “one nail by strength drives out another” (II.4), and reasons from a broken vow to attempted rape in plausible steps, each one sounding like honesty. “I to myself am dearer than a friend” is true, and it is the whole problem. Sonnet 129 is the summary: lust is “past reason hunted, and no sooner had / Past reason hated,” and the couplet admits the knowledge does nothing: “All this the world well knows yet none knows well, / To shun the heaven that leads men to this hell.”

Romeo and Juliet is often read as love defeated by hate; what the text shows is love defeated by speed. Juliet names the danger on the first night, “too like the lightning” (II.2), and proposes marriage anyway. The Friar names it and performs the marriage anyway. Nobody is stupid. They all know the thing that would save them is delay, and delay feels like death.

Venus and Adonis shows the appetite from the other side, in the one who wants. The goddess of love is an eagle, a glutton, a vulture; Adonis says “you crush me; let me go” and is right; and when the boar kills him she understands it at once, because she would have done the same “had I been tooth’d like him.” The wish to possess and the wish to consume are not distinct, and the thing desired knows it. Adonis’s one argument, “Before I know myself, seek not to know me,” is the most reasonable sentence in the poem, and the poem grants it and kills him the next morning. Reasonableness is not protection.

A Lover’s Complaint adds the last turn: knowing how you will be deceived does not stop it. The woman lists the man’s record before he speaks. She is beaten by a confession and a tear, and she ends by saying the same confession and tear would beat her again. The old man she tells this to was asked for counsel and gives none.

The corpus’s view is that inconstancy is not usually a lie told to others. It is a story told to oneself, and the story is always available.

6. We do not own ourselves; who we are is given by others and can be taken back

The Comedy of Errors is a farce built on a frightening proposition: a man with twenty years of reputation, a wife, a house, and a scar from saving the Duke’s life can be bound as a lunatic in one afternoon on the honest testimony of honest witnesses. Nobody lies. The sum of partial views is enough. The Taming of the Shrew runs the experiment twice, on a drunk told he is a lord and on a woman told the sun is the moon, and in both cases the subject ends by saying what the room says.

The tragedies say it at a higher pitch. Coriolanus stands “as if a man were author of himself, / And knew no other kin” (V.3), and his mother kneels, and he yields, and asks “What have you done?” Richard II, deposed, finds “nor I nor any man that but man is / With nothing shall be pleased till he be eased / With being nothing” (V.5). Antony, losing, sees himself as a cloud that “dislimns” until it is “indistinct / As water is in water” (IV.14); his identity was a performance that needed an audience, and the audience has left. Othello, with no war to fight, says “Othello’s occupation’s gone” (III.3), and the self goes with it. Ulysses tells Achilles that no man “feels what he owes, but by reflection” (III.3), which makes everyone manageable by a withheld look.

Names are the sharpest version. “What’s in a name?” asks Juliet, and the name is what kills them. Hamlet’s dying wish is for his “wounded name.” Coriolanus’s name was given by others for a city he took, and others take it back.

Part Two: What we do to each other

7. Everyone performs, and refusing to perform is refusing to act

Hamlet says “I know not seems” (I.2) and then does nothing but seem for four acts. Iago says “I am not what I am” (I.1) and is called “honest” on every tongue. Richard III announces exactly what he is in the first speech and people still see what they prefer; the Scrivener asks “Who is so gross / That cannot see this palpable device? / Yet who so bold but says he sees it not?” (III.6). Hal plans his reformation as a stage effect (1 Henry IV I.2), and the plan works, and makes him unreadable even to himself. Macbeth must “look like the innocent flower, / But be the serpent under’t” (I.5). Cymbeline’s people know each other by bracelets and moles and the shape of a leg on a headless corpse.

This is the most frequent preoccupation in the whole corpus; the notes on thirty-one of the forty-two note files name it. But the finding is not the cheap one, that people are liars. It is that performance is the condition of action. Coriolanus is the test: he will not counterfeit humility in the marketplace, and the one time he bends, at his mother’s knee, it kills him. Volumnia’s argument that dissembling is honour in war and baseness in peace “and the difference may be nothing but custom” (III.2) is sound, and his reply that a body that kneels teaches the mind to kneel is also sound. The plays do not resolve this. They show that the person who refuses to act a part refuses to act.

And yet in nearly every play the corpus keeps one person alive who performs nothing: Cordelia, Kent, Horatio, Enobarbus, Viola, Hermione, the old servant Adam, Flavius. They are mostly powerless in the plot. Hamlet’s praise of Horatio is the one speech of unguarded love he makes: “Give me that man / That is not passion’s slave” (III.2). The plays are honest that the plain speaker usually loses, and honest that the plain speaker is what they value.

8. Cruelty is learned by imitation, and revenge cannot stop itself

Shylock: “The villainy you teach me I will execute, and it shall go hard but I will better the instruction” (III.1). Macbeth: “we but teach / Bloody instructions, which being taught, return / To plague th’ inventor” (I.7). Clifford to a child: “Thy father slew my father; therefore die” (3 Henry VI I.3). Prospero’s usurpation by his brother teaches Antonio to tempt Sebastian to the same deed on the same island. Titus Andronicus is the pure form: every atrocity is committed under a principle (piety, honour, law, precedent), and the only honest account comes from Aaron, who claims none.

What the corpus adds to the obvious point is that **everyone's cruelty is a quotation**. Antonio spits; Shylock whets his knife; Gratiano crows "a halter gratis." Margaret kills York for her son; the sons of York kill her son; she curses their children; Richard goes to the Tower. Every payment is a new debt. The plays draw the machinery of feud with no parts hidden, and the only character in any of them who can stop a cycle is one with the power to simply decline: Prospero, who says "the rarer action is / In virtue than in vengeance" (V.1), and forgives a brother who does not answer.

9. Mercy is real, rarely rewarded, and chosen by the strong for their own sake

The corpus asks for mercy constantly and shows it refused by nearly everyone with the power to grant it. Tamora preaches that "sweet mercy is nobility's true badge" (Titus I.1) while pleading, and refuses it in the next act while ruling. Isabella tells Angelo "it is excellent / To have a giant's strength; but it is tyrannous / To use it like a giant" (II.2), and Angelo, moved, propositions her. Portia's speech changes nothing. Henry VI pities everyone, and his pity buys nothing; every active person in his plays calls it weakness, and he dies with the only unbroken conscience in three plays.

When mercy does come, it comes from above and is not earned by the one receiving it. Prospero forgives Antonio for the sake of what kind of action is rare, not because Antonio deserves it, and keeps a threat in reserve: "at this time / I will tell no tales" (V.1). Posthumus in Cymbeline forgives Imogen while he still believes her guilty, which is the only forgiveness in the corpus that costs the forgiver anything; the play then has him strike her to the ground before he knows who she is. Forgiveness in Shakespeare is a repeated act, not a state, and it changes the forgiver more than the forgiven. Coriolanus's one act of mercy is the right act and the fatal one. The plays never say mercy pays. They say it is "the word" (Cymbeline V.5), and leave you to decide whether that is enough.

10. Power is a costume; the body underneath is like any other, and it learns this last

"A dog's obeyed in office" (Lear IV.6). "Through tatter'd clothes great vices do appear; / Robes and furr'd gowns hide all" (same scene). Richard II, deposed: "I live with bread like you, feel want, / Taste grief, need friends" (III.2). Henry V, in another man's cloak, to a soldier: "the King is but a man as I am. The violet smells to him as it doth to me" (IV.1). Isabella: "man, proud man, / Dressed in a little brief authority, / Most ignorant of what he's most assured" (II.2). Buckingham, Katherine, and Wolsey in Henry VIII each discover "this is the state of man" at the instant of losing the state.

The histories add a specific mechanism: **the oblique command**. Henry IV mutters “Have I no friend will rid me of this living fear?” and then cannot bear the man who did it (Richard II V.4, V.6). John says “Death.” “A grave.” “Enough.” and blames Hubert for understanding (III.3, IV.2). Henry V orders the prisoners killed and Gower supplies the excuse afterward (IV.6, IV.7). The powerful in this corpus will an outcome and refuse the deed, in language, and the plays show the disowning every time. Henry V says a king is only a man, and arranges for a Welshman to take the blow meant for him.

And always the disproportion between the speech and the list: “we band of brothers... this day shall gentle his condition” (Henry V IV.3), followed by the count of the dead, “None else of name; and of all other men / But five and twenty” (IV.8).

11. Loyalty lives at the bottom and is paid in sorrow; the crowd goes to the sun

Kent follows in disguise. The Fool follows into the storm. Flavius follows Timon into the woods with his own savings. Adam gives Orlando his life’s wages. Pisanio disobeys an order to kill and is cursed by the woman he saved. Camillo flees rather than poison a guest. Enobarbus is right about everything, leaves Antony on reason’s advice, and dies of having done it. Antonio in Twelfth Night loves most and is forgotten by the plot. The Jailer’s Daughter in Two Noble Kinsmen is the only person who actually acts for love and is cured by a lie. A nameless servant in Lear draws his sword on his master to stop a blinding and is killed for it.

Meanwhile: “the people” in Julius Caesar cheer Pompey, then Caesar, then Brutus, then Antony, and tear a poet apart for his name. In 2 Henry VI the crowd is “both right and monstrous, and it turns on a word.” In Coriolanus they vote and revoke within the hour. In Richard II the love of the crowd “is purchased and follows the winner.” Edward IV’s keepers say it plainest: “we were subjects but while you were king” (3 Henry VI III.1).

The corpus’s judgment here is steady across every genre. **Faithfulness survives at the bottom of the social order when it has vanished from the top, and it is paid nothing.** The plays do not pretend otherwise and do not stop honouring it. What they do, over and over, is let the servant or the woman see clearly what the master or the lover cannot: “If you want to know whether a person is to be trusted, ask the people who carry his letters.”

Lucrece is the sharpest instance. The narrator of that poem says women are wax and men are marble, stamped by force and not to be blamed. The heroine is the one unstamped will in the story. She argues politics better than the men, decides the only thing anyone decides, and as soon as she

is dead her body becomes someone else's argument, carried through Rome by Brutus. The people called passive by the theories around them are often the ones acting, and the theories survive anyway.

12. Love attaches to surfaces, vows are the least reliable oaths, and the constant love is the silent one

Olivia marries a face she has never spoken to; Sebastian tells her so. Orsino takes as wife the boy he confided in. Viola's speech about the sister who "sat like patience on a monument, / Smiling at grief" (II.4) is the play's truest account of love, and she is rewarded by pure luck. Cordelia says "Nothing" and is the only daughter whose love returns. Hermione, restored, says nothing to her husband; she speaks to her daughter. Imogen, "the faithful woman," is the one who moves, disguises, lies, and chooses.

Against these, every loud lover in the corpus breaks his word. Proteus, Bertram, Claudio, Troilus's Cressida, the young man of the Sonnets, Romeo before Juliet, Demetrius, the King of Navarre and his lords, who swear off women for three years and last a week. Balthasar's song says "Men were deceivers ever... To one thing constant never" (Much Ado II.3), and the play agrees. Diana in All's Well: "'tis not the many oaths that makes the truth, / But the plain single vow that is vow'd true" (IV.2). The Princess in Love's Labour's Lost will not accept words at all; she asks for a year of doing.

The hardest version is in Troilus: when the eyes report what the belief cannot accept, the lover splits the beloved rather than revise the belief. "This is, and is not, Cressid" (V.2). The Sonnets end in the same knot, both parties lying and knowing it: "Therefore I lie with her, and she with me, / And in our faults by lies we flattered be" (138). And yet the corpus will not let love be only an accident of surfaces. Cleopatra builds an Antony out of words whose "legs bestrid the ocean," Dolabella says no such man ever lived, and Caesar, the clearest-eyed man in the play, weeps for him anyway. What people make of their lives in the telling may outweigh what they did.

There is one place in the whole corpus where love is neither a predator, a lie, nor a wound. The Phoenix and the Turtle says two can be one, that reason is simply wrong about this, and that the union left no child and that is its perfection. It is a funeral. Truth and beauty, the poem says, now lie in the urn, and it calls for mourners it has just said no longer exist. The corpus can imagine love without deceit only as something already dead.

13. Words are the faculty that ruins and the faculty that restores, and the plays cannot separate the two

Othello is destroyed by talk alone; there is no witch, no ghost, just one man speaking to another and a handkerchief. He had told the Senate that talk was how he won his wife. Richard III wins Anne over the corpse of the man he killed, by words, once. Much Ado's lovers are made by a rumour and its bride is unmade by one. Lear's catastrophe begins with a demand that love be spoken.

But Paulina says "It is requir'd / You do awake your faith" (Winter's Tale V.3), and a statue is warm. The capacity that destroyed Leontes, belief in what is not there, is the same capacity that lets him embrace his wife; the play cannot tell you how to have the second without the first. It can show the difference in fruit: one belief made nothings of everything, the other says "O, she's warm."

The Sonnets are the record of a man who knows that verse does not actually defeat time, that "brass eternal" is "slave to mortal rage" (64), and who keeps writing because the writing is a way of being faithful when he is not. "Why write I still all one, ever the same" (76) is answered by continuing. Constancy, in this corpus, is sometimes something you can only do with words, and the plays count that as both a real thing and a confession.

Part Three: What happens to us

14. Time undoes everything, and the only answer offered is readiness, which is nearly unbearable

“Like as the waves make towards the pebbled shore, / So do our minutes hasten to their end” (Sonnet 60). “Time hath, my lord, a wallet at his back, / Wherein he puts alms for oblivion” (Troilus III.3). “Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow, / Creeps in this petty pace from day to day” (Macbeth V.5). “The cloud-capp’d towers, the gorgeous palaces, / The solemn temples, the great globe itself... shall dissolve” (Tempest IV.1). Henry IV, sleepless: “O God, that one might read the book of fate... The happiest youth, viewing his progress through, / What perils past, what crosses to ensue, / Would shut the book, and sit him down and die” (2 Henry IV III.1). Feste’s last song: “the rain it raineth every day.”

What the corpus offers against this is not consolation but posture. Hamlet: “If it be now, ‘tis not to come; if it be not to come, it will be now; if it be not now, yet it will come. The readiness is all” (V.2). Edgar: “Men must endure / Their going hence, even as their coming hither; / Ripeness is all” (Lear V.2). Pericles: fourteen years of sackcloth and three months of silence, and the play is careful to show that patience is not serenity. Lear’s own version: “Thou must be patient; we came crying hither” (IV.6).

Note what the plays do with these speeches. Hamlet says “the readiness is all” and walks into a rigged match he half suspects. Edgar says “ripeness is all” and Cordelia is hanged. The posture is real and it is the nearest thing to peace anyone achieves, and the plays will not let it look like an answer.

15. Death levels everyone, the living reassert distinctions anyway, and the fear of death wins in the body

The gravedigger handles the skulls of a politician, a courtier, a lawyer, a jester, alike. “Your fat king and your lean beggar is but variable service,—two dishes, but to one table” (Hamlet IV.3). Alexander stops a bung-hole. “Golden lads and girls all must, / As chimney-sweepers, come to dust” (Cymbeline IV.2). Richard II: “within the hollow crown / That rounds the mortal temples of a king / Keeps Death his court” (III.2). Warwick, kingmaker, dies with “nothing left me but my body’s length” (3 Henry VI V.2).

But the same gravedigger notes that Ophelia gets Christian burial only because “great folk should have countenance in this world to drown or hang themselves more than their even Christian” (V.1). Even the funeral is rigged by rank. Death levels; the living do not.

And the plays set two speeches against each other that a reader has to hold at once. The Duke in *Measure for Measure* tells Claudio to “Be absolute for death,” that life is “a breath,” “death’s fool,” that “what’s yet in this / That bears the name of life?” (III.1). It is a complete and nearly convincing argument. Claudio accepts it. Then his sister comes, and he says: “Ay, but to die, and go we know not where; / To lie in cold obstruction, and to rot... The weariest and most loathed worldly life / That age, ache, penury, and imprisonment / Can lay on nature is a paradise / To what we fear of death” (III.1). “Sweet sister, let me live.” The body wins. Hamlet’s “undiscover’d country” “puzzles the will” for the same reason. Caesar says “Cowards die many times before their deaths” (II.2) and is dead within the hour. The corpus respects the philosophy of death and shows, every time, that it is not what people do.

16. Justice is asked for and not delivered; the plays keep two accounts of causation running and refuse to choose

“As flies to wanton boys are we to the gods, / They kill us for their sport” (*Lear* IV.1). “The gods are just, and of our pleasant vices / Make instruments to plague us” (*Lear* V.3). Both are said in the same play, by sympathetic people, and the play places each next to an event that mocks it. Albany says “the gods defend her” and *Lear* enters with Cordelia’s body. Kent asks “Is this the promis’d end?” and nobody answers.

Hamlet finds “a divinity that shapes our ends” (V.2) and the divinity brings the king to justice only after bringing the queen, Laertes, and Hamlet to death, and the throne to a foreigner. *Cymbeline*’s Jupiter says “Whom best I love I cross,” and Posthumus, waking, says he has “this golden chance, and know not why,” that many “are steep’d in favours” who deserve nothing (V.4, V.5). Pericles’ chorus says virtue was “led on by heaven,” and the text has shown Thaisa preserved by a doctor’s craft and Marina by pirates. In *Two Noble Kinsmen* every prayer is answered exactly, and the exactness is what kills Arcite; Theseus closes by telling everyone to stop asking. Edgar, in *Lear*: “The worst is not / So long as we can say ‘This is the worst’” (IV.1).

The corpus’s honesty here is that in a long life you cannot tell which of your rescues were providence and which were luck, and the plays decline to tell you. What they offer instead of an argument is a handful of people: Cordelia saying “No cause, no cause” (IV.7), Kent in disguise, the servant with the sword. The strongest evidence against meaning is that all three are dead or

disregarded by the end. The reader has to decide whether goodness that gets no reward and changes nothing is worth something anyway. The plays seem to think so, and seem to know how little that settles.

17. The winners write the verdict, and the last word goes to someone who can say the simple thing the play has made impossible

Malcolm: “this dead butcher, and his fiend-like queen.” Fortinbras gives Hamlet a soldier’s funeral for what he “was likely” to have been. Lodovico: “all that’s spoke is marr’d.” The Prince in Verona: “all are punish’d.” Octavius, who hunted Antony, orders him buried with honour. Lucius in Titus asks the Romans whether the Andronici did anything wrong, and the Romans say no. Henry IV, as the sun rises on his victory: “nothing can seem foul to those that win” (1 Henry IV V.1), which the play means as description, not endorsement.

Every tragedy spends five acts making the simple verdict impossible, and then hands the last word to someone who can still say it. This is not carelessness. It is the corpus’s observation about how the living talk about the dead, and about how history is written: Henry V’s old soldiers will “remember with advantages” (IV.3), and the Chorus admits that the glory lived whole only in the audience’s thoughts.

18. The happy ending is a point of view, and someone who is not at the party pays for it

Malvolio leaves swearing revenge on “the whole pack of you,” and Olivia and Orsino both say he was wronged. Shylock leaves sick and does not return; the couples go in. Jaques declines the dance and is not wrong. Antonio stands dumb among the married. Silvia has no line after “O heaven!” Hermione speaks to her daughter and not her husband, and Mamillius does not come back. Helena in Dream gets her man by a drug and knows it is “mine own, and not mine own.” The “double cherry” friendship of Hermia and Helena ends with “I will not trust you” and is never mended. Isabella is silent at the Duke’s proposal. Bertram’s love is an “if.” Love’s Labour’s Lost says of itself, “Jack hath not Jill.”

The comedies know this. They put the knowledge in a servant’s mouth or a woman’s silence and leave it there. The note on Twelfth Night says it exactly: “the party has a cost and the bill is always delivered to someone who is not at the party.” The restoration at the end of a comedy is a restoration, not a repair; the household is put back as it was, faults included.

19. No one is one thing; and the person who is one thing only is either destroyed or the most dangerous in the room

“The web of our life is of a mingled yarn, good and ill together; our virtues would be proud if our faults whipped them not; and our crimes would despair if they were not cherish’d by our virtues” (All’s Well IV.3). Diana’s riddle in the last scene, “he’s guilty, and he is not guilty,” is the play’s account of a person. Brutus is “the noblest Roman” and the author of every disaster. Othello could say “the pity of it, Iago” in the same breath as “I will chop her into messes” (IV.1), and the play’s honesty is that these are not alternatives. Richard II is the worst king and the best seer. Bertram is a coward and a war hero. Hal is handsome in every act and every act is an investment.

The people who are one thing only: Coriolanus, who has “exactly one way of being, and a world that needs him to have two,” and is torn to pieces. Richard III, “I am myself alone” (3 Henry VI V.6), the only man in his play who tells the truth about himself, and the kingdom has nobody left who can recognise him. Timon, who loves all mankind and then hates all mankind, and never in either case sees one person at a time: “The middle of humanity thou never knewest, but the extremity of both ends” (IV.3).

This last is one of the corpus’s quietest and most useful findings: **a judgment about “mankind” is always a way of avoiding a judgment about someone in front of you.** Timon’s misanthropy is refuted by particular people, Flavius above all, and Timon keeps the thesis rather than the man.

Part Four: What it teaches

Having read all of this, what does the corpus actually teach a single person? Not a philosophy; the plays dismantle every philosophy they state. But there is a residue, and it can be said plainly.

1. You will know the right thing and not do it, and knowing this in advance will not help much. The plays' most frequent subject is the gap between the maxim and the life. The useful part of the lesson is the second half: do not expect more knowledge to close the gap, and do not expect less knowledge to close it either (Hamlet's one unthinking act kills the wrong man). What the plays respect is not knowledge but the people who keep faith without needing to understand why: Kent, Horatio, Flavius, Cordelia. They do not win. They are what the plays value.

2. You will be wrong about the people closest to you, and the alternative is worse. Othello, Leontes, Claudio, Posthumus, Cymbeline, Lear, Gloucester. Every one misreads someone they love, and in every case the misreading is supplied by the reader's own disposition, not by the evidence. The corpus does not conclude that you should trust less. Its one explicit verdict is Cymbeline's: it would have been "vicious" to mistrust. The counsel, if it is one, is to notice that your certainty about a person is a product of your wishes, and that the moment of greatest conviction, "I am constant as the northern star," may be the moment before the knife.

3. Nothing you are told will reach you; only what you feel will. This is hard advice because it cannot be acted on. But it has a corollary that can be: be slow to counsel the suffering, since "everyone can master a grief but he that has it," and be aware that your own understanding is bounded by what you have been spared. Lear's "I have ta'en too little care of this" is a discovery available only to a man in the rain.

4. Cruelty is contagious, and only the strong can stop the chain, and they rarely do. If you have power over someone who wronged you, the corpus's one example of a cycle ending is Prospero's: forgive for the sake of what kind of action is rare, not because it is deserved, and expect no answer. Forgiveness changes you. It does not change them. It is also a repeated act, not a state: Posthumus forgives and then knocks her down.

5. Who you are is held in trust by other people, and they can withdraw it. Reputation is credit that can be called in an afternoon. Labels ("shrew," "modest," "honest") are made by treatment and can be reversed by treatment. The person who believes himself "author of himself" is refuted by

the person who made him. The practical lesson is double: be careful what you let people agree about you, and be careful what you agree about others, since your partial view, added to everyone else's, is enough to bind a sane man in a cellar.

6. Desire will move faster than you and then explain itself as reason. The corpus is exact about the sound of this: "I to myself am dearer than a friend." "Now do I wish it, love it, long for it." The Sonnets admit that knowing the pattern does not stop it. What the plays do honour is a different tempo: the Princess's year, Viola's patience on a monument, the "plain single vow." Love that announces itself most loudly is the least reliable. The constant love is usually the one with the fewest lines.

7. Time will take everything, and the only stance that survives the plays' scrutiny is readiness. Not because readiness fixes anything (Hamlet dies in the next scene) but because every other stance, Macbeth's numbness, Richard's wailing, the Duke's "be absolute for death," is shown to be either a lie or unlivable. "Ripeness is all" is said by a man who is about to lose everything and does not take it back.

8. The verdict on your life will be written by someone who did not understand it. Fortinbras, Malcolm, Lodovico. Hamlet's last wish is that someone "absent thee from felicity awhile" to tell his story right, and the person who does, Horatio, is immediately overruled by a soldier's funeral. There is nothing to do about this except to notice that it is true of the people whose verdicts you are writing.

9. The ending that is happy for you was paid for by someone who is not in the room. Every comedy leaves one person on stage to say so. A reader of these plays acquires the habit of asking, at every celebration, who is not dancing and why.

10. No one is one thing, and the attempt to be one thing is either fatal or monstrous. "He's guilty, and he is not guilty." The mingled yarn is not a consolation; it is a description. The practical form of it is Apemantus's line to Timon: the person who judges "mankind" in bulk has stopped looking at the person in front of him. Every total verdict about people in the corpus, Timon's hatred, Timon's love, Lear's "none does offend," Thersites' "lechery eats itself," is accurate in detail and refuted by one particular person it failed to count.

What the corpus refuses to teach

It will not tell you whether the gods are just. It will not tell you whether Hamlet should have acted sooner, whether Brutus should have let Caesar live, whether Cordelia should have flattered, whether Hal is good, whether it is better to be Antony or Octavius. It will not tell you whether

Macbeth's witches were fate or desire spoken aloud by someone else. It will not tell you whether Katherina believes her last speech, or whether Caliban's repentance is sincere, or whether Leontes' sixteen years were heaven's sentence or Paulina's. It states every question with great force and places the evidence for both answers side by side.

This is not evasion. It is the corpus's most consistent observation about the human condition: that the people inside a life cannot see it whole, that the verdicts available to them are all partial, and that the honest position is to hold both halves. Edgar's last line in *Lear* is the nearest thing to an instruction the plays give: "Speak what we feel, not what we ought to say." That is where that play began, with a daughter who would not say what she ought, and it ends by endorsing her at a price that makes the endorsement very hard to take as comfort.

Questions to argue with

For discussion, these are the places where I think a reader can most profitably push back on the synthesis above, or on the plays.

1. The corpus honours the plain speaker and the faithful servant and shows them losing. Is that an argument for plain speech, or an observation that the world punishes it? Can it be both?
2. “Evidence is downstream of charity.” If so, is there any such thing as seeing a person clearly, or only seeing them kindly or unkindly?
3. Prospero’s forgiveness changes Prospero and not Antonio. Is forgiveness that does not reach its object still forgiveness, or is it only self-care with a nobler name?
4. Coriolanus bends once and dies for it. Is the corpus saying that integrity is fatal, or that it is fatal only in a world that has already gone wrong? And which world do we live in?
5. The comedies restore rather than repair. Is that a failure of the plays, or an honest account of how people actually settle things: quickly, in words, with the injured party silent?
6. Timon: a judgment about “mankind” is a way of avoiding a judgment about someone in front of you. Does the same apply to this essay?
7. Every tragedy hands the last word to someone who can say the simple thing. Is the simple verdict always wrong, or is it sometimes the only verdict a community can live with?

Where to go next

- The per-play notes in notes/ each end with “What it teaches” and “Preoccupations.” Start with Lear, Hamlet, Measure for Measure, All’s Well, Troilus, and the Sonnets, which carry most of the weight above.
- For the “speech beside the body” method, read Jaques’s seven ages (As You Like It II.7) and watch who enters next; then Ulysses on degree (Troilus I.3) and what happens to the lottery; then Sonnets 116 and 117 together.
- For the gap between knowing and doing, read Macbeth I.7 and then III.1; Richard II III.2 and V.5; Hamlet III.1, III.3, and IV.4 in order.
- For justice, read Lear IV.1, IV.6, V.3 straight through.
- For what love is, read Twelfth Night II.4 (patience on a monument), Troilus V.2 (this is and is not Cressid), Antony V.2 (the dream Antony), and Sonnet 138.

Notes for all 44 works are in notes/. The three shortest poems share one file.